conviction of some of the accused. In November 2018, the court of the additional sessions judge, Delhi, awarded the death sentence to Yashpal Singh and a life sentence to his co-accused, Naresh Sherawat, for the murder of two Sikh brothers from the Rangpuri area. On 28 November 2018, the Delhi High Court, setting aside a twenty-two-year-old appeal, upheld the five-year sentence awarded by the trial court to seventy of the eighty-nine accused for their role in the violence in the East Delhi area of Trilokpuri in 1984. However, the Supreme Court, on 30 April 2019, acquitted seven of these persons. Finally, on 17 December 2019, in a much-awaited judgment, the Delhi High Court awarded a life sentence to Congress politician Sajjan Kumar. [9]

Pak-sponsored activities in the West

Taking advantage of the prolonged denial of justice to the Sikhs by successive governments of India, Pakistan started making concerted efforts to internationalize the Khalistan issue by using their existing and newly created assets living in Pakistan, India and the Western countries, especially the UK, Canada and the US. Of these, the US-based organization Sikhs for Justice (SFJ), led by Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, had been the most vocal in the last few years.

At a rally held in London's Trafalgar Square on 12 August 2018, in which some separatist Kashmiris also participated, it was decided to 're-establish Punjab as an independent country' and hold 'Punjab Referendum 2020' in twenty cities in India, the US, Canada, the UK, Australia, New Zealand and some other European and Asian countries, to coincide with the thirty-sixth anniversary of the anti-Sikh pogrom of November 1984.

Keeping in view the anti-national and subversive activities of Sikhs for Justice, the Government of India declared this group an 'unlawful association' in July 2019, under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). [10] However, sensing that its agenda had little appeal among the Sikh masses in India and abroad, SFJ has since invited all communities, including Dalits, to participate in the so-called Punjab Referendum. [11]